

The Forgotten HEROES

Almost four centuries after Shivaji and his soldiers did themselves proud against Aurangzeb's armies, their descendants are waiting for these warriors to get their rightful place in history

| By Uday Mahurkar |

Photographs by SHAILESH RAVAL

The year was 1665. Diler Khan, Emperor Aurangzeb's Pathan commander, had laid siege to the gigantic fort of Purandar near Pune. Behind the massive walls were Chhatrapati Shivaji's soldiers led by Murar Baji, a Kayastha commander. With just 60 men, Baji stormed the Mughal army, slaying 500 Pathans. Legend has it that Khan stopped the battle midway and addressed Baji, "I have never seen a braver soldier and better swordsman than you. We will be privileged to have you. Join us and you will be rewarded." Baji refused. In the ensuing battle, he was killed by an arrow shot by Khan.

During the 17th century, the Marathas stood fast against Aurangzeb, not allowing him to venture into their lands even once. Maratha generals like Santaji Ghorpade, Dhanaji Jadhav, Vithoji Chavan Himmat Bahadur, Kanhoji Jedhe and Shivaji's son-in-law Harji Rajemahadik repeatedly defeated the Mughals in south India between 1685 and 1707. They captured many Mughal generals till Shivaji's death in 1680, after which Aurangzeb left Agra for south India to annihilate them. It took Aurangzeb 22 long years to defeat the Marathas in the south. The Marathas—along with Shivaji and his two sons, Sambaji and Raja Ram—are household names in Maharashtra today. Many others share the honour—Shivaji's commander-in-chief Hambirrao Mohite; Muslim commanders Noor Beg and Darya Khan; and Khanderao Dabhade, who headed the Maratha army under



**PADMASENRAJE DABHADE (RIGHT),
DESCENDANT OF KAHNDERAO DABHADE,
COMMANDER-IN-CHIEF OF THE MARATHA
ARMY WHO EXTENDED MARATHA RULE
BEYOND THE NARMADA RIVER**

